The emperor, having heard some excerpts, declared, ‘Excepting love and devotion to God I so far find neither praise nor blame of any one in this Granth. It is a volume worthy of reverence.’[13]

Poets, philosophers and saints might argue, emperors might adjudicate, but what of the everyday Hindustanis who practised what they preached? It might be almost impossible to imagine any of these lives were it not for the wonderful autobiography of a Jain trader and poet called Banarasidas.[14] In a lucid, honest and often very funny account of his adventures (beautifully translated by Rohini Chowdhury), Banarasidas includes his struggles with ritual and faith. In his youth, writes Banarasi, he fell for a sanyasi’s get-rich-quick scheme, and bought a mantra that he was to recite every day for a year, after which, every day, a gold coin would appear at his door for the rest of his life. ‘For an entire year, every day,’ writes Banarasidas, ‘With firm and unwavering belief, / In the solitude and secrecy of the privy / Banarasi, the blockhead, recited the mantra . . .’ A year later, he opened his front door. No immediate glitter caught his eye. Poor Banarasi ‘examined the ground carefully’ – no doubt growing more annoyed with every desperate scrutiny of the soil and shadows. ‘He found no dinar anywhere.’

It was a blow, but it did not end Banarasi’s quest. The young man would go on to experiment with Saivism, then return to his own Jain faith, but never to find the spiritual satisfaction he sought. ‘The performance of rituals no longer held any joy for him,’ writes the merchant of himself, ‘But he could not appreciate the spiritual aspects either. / Banarasi’s condition became similar to / That of a camel’s fart, which hangs between earth and air.’ Eventually, Banarasidas gave up on all forms of worship and ritual, veering full tilt into heresy instead, so much so that he would even eat the food left in offering to the gods.

So, it seems, a man could journey from superstition to scepticism as freely as Banarasidas travelled from Jaunpur to Agra for his trade.[15] That is not to say, however, that religious belief imposed no constraints on how people were allowed to live.

Thus, Badauni tells the tragic tale of an inter-religious (and adulterous) love affair. Romance, it seems, was the otherwise sardonic Badauni’s Achilles heel – himself not above canoodling in a dargah, he couldn’t resist a good love story, whether between Ali Quli and that beautiful rake, Shahim